
The London Free Press

Serving London, Ontario Since 1849

LONDON, ONTARIO · COMMUNITY CONTRIBUTIONS · JANUARY 25, 2021

Photo: Christmas shopping at Dundas and Richmond Sts., December 24, 1954 (LFP Coll) — Western Libraries, Western University



A Reflection on the Achievements of the London Italian-Canadian Community

Originally delivered at the Italian Canadian Archives Project Annual Conference, Western University, 2016

By Pasquale Palombo · January 25, 2021

A BIRD'S EYE VIEW

It was a mid-September day a few years ago that I was summoned, for the fourth time, to appear in court on jury duty, and with my luck I was selected as one of the jurors. During these 3 days, we were ordered from time to time to recess in a room on the 14th floor, and discuss the findings of the case we were called to witness and eventually reach a verdict.

It was during these breaks that I had the opportunity to admire the astonishing beauty of a London I had never witnessed before. In fact, looking through the windows so high above ground, I had a bird's eye view of Labatt's Park baseball diamond on the right, the forks of the Thames on the left, and next to it, the Art Gallery, Museum London.

Just past these 3 landmarks, a canopy of green that extended almost to the horizon and engulfed the rest of the city in bucolic scenery. I saw it under sunny skies, under the rain and the following sunny breaks but my awe never changed and if

anything, it made me realize why our London is also recognized appropriately as "The Forest City."

THE PIONEERS

I would refer to these people as the pioneers of our community. People who brought with themselves all those essential human values: honesty, integrity, and most importantly, the values of hard work, the ability to save money, spirit of self-denial, but above all else, love and total commitment to the family. That has always been the pillar of our civilization; virtues and principals "allattate dal seno materno."

In many cases, these were illiterate or semi-illiterate individuals whom, despite all odds, had refused all compromise of a meager and less than honorable existence to provide an opportunity for a better life to their children and grandchildren. As the ancient Romans used to say: "ubi panis, ibi patria" — "where it is well, there is one's country."

"Fatti non foste a viver come bruti, ma per seguir virtute e conoscenza" — "not to

exist like brutes, but made were ye to follow virtue and intelligence." — Dante Alighieri, Divina Commedia

ENDURING HARDSHIP

They chose to come to a country whose languages and culture they didn't know, a country practically inhabitable during its frigid winter months, and they were prepared to endure humiliation and racist epithets due to their diversity. They accepted the humblest of works, they worked long hours, in many cases working more than 1 job, and on occasion they walked and covered considerable distances to reach their workplace.

None of these difficulties diminished their commitment, nor undermined their determination to progress and achieve their goals. In many cases, and despite the lack of basic education, they showed a remarkable forward-thinking ability to inspire their children by impressing upon them the importance of schooling and higher education.

NOTABLE CONTRIBUTIONS

Therefore, I deemed it necessary to draft a list of commendable Italian-Canadians, or Canadians from Italian descent, who through their hard work and dedication, made an invaluable contribution in many fields towards the betterment of our city and our society at large.

Politics

Orlando Zampogna — Elected in 1970. Served as deputy mayor to 3 mayors: Jane Bigelow, Al Gleeson, Tom Gosnell.

Anne Marie De Cicco-Best — 60th and longest serving mayor of London. Took office December 4, 2000 to November 30, 2010. First elected to city council in 1991 in ward 5.

Joe Fontana — Liberal MP from 1987 to 2006. Mayor of London from 2010 to his conviction for fraud and forgery in 2014.

Frank Mazzilli — Elected June 3, 1999 to September 2, 2003. Parliamentary assistant to the Minister of Tourism, Culture, and Recreation.

Roger Caranci — Councillor for 3 terms. Ran for Liberal MPP and subsequently for mayor.

Fred Tranquilli — Elected councillor in ward 3, 1997–2003. From 2006 to present, partner with Lerner LLP.

Irene Mathysen — MPP of Ontario 1990–1995. Elected MP in 2006 for London Fanshawe riding; re-elected in 2008, 2011, and 2015.

Religious Positions

Bishop Ronald Peter Fabbro — Born November 6, 1950 in Sudbury, Ontario. Appointed April 27, 2002. Elected President of the Assembly (ACBO) on March 9, 2016.

Police Services

Julian Fantino — Former Chief of Police in London and Toronto. Elected MP for the riding of Vaughan, November 29, 2010, until his defeat in 2015.

Health Care

Tony Dagnone — President and CEO of London Health Sciences Centre. Appointed Board Chair of the Ontario Hospital Association in 1992. Granted the Order of Canada for community work and leadership in healthcare. Awarded the Queen's Jubilee Medal in 2003. Retired December 31, 2005 after 38 years.

Dr. Rolando Del Maestro — Medical degree from Western Ontario, 1973. PhD in Biochemistry, University of Uppsala, Sweden, 1979. Director of Brain Research Laboratories 1981–2000. Professor of Neurosurgery from 1991. Recruited by the

Montreal Neurological Institute at McGill University in 2000.

Construction & Development

Some of the most successful people in the local construction industry are also Italian and have contributed to the changing shape of our city's skyline:

Tricar Group — President Joe Carapella.

Southside Group — President Vito Frijia. Also president and owner of the London Lightning basketball team.

Domus Developments London Inc. — Family owned. Specializing in award-winning residential condominium projects.

Law

Claude Pensa — Founder and Partner of London legal practice Harrison Pensa LLP.

***“Our success has been unequalled,
unparalleled and unprecedented.”***

As you might have noticed, our Italian-Canadian community of London Ontario has vastly contributed and distinguished itself in the promotion of family values while actively participating in the social, political, economic, religious, and law and order aspects of our society.

The 20-year period between 1990 and 2010 represented the apogee in our history. And this is why we might confidently say that our success has been unequalled, unparalleled and unprecedented. And this, Ladies and Gentlemen, is the reason why we like to call London, Ontario, the Forest City, our home.

*Contributions from the Community · The London
Free Press · London, Ontario*
